

Chapter 164-2

After a while, Liang Shi said seriously: "You were acting."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

"I really won't leave." Liang Shi said, "And I really do love you. Please don't make me feel bad by putting yourself down, okay? I like you. Hearing you say bad things about yourself hurts more than hearing you scold me."

Liang Shi never turned around. Although her hands were doing things, she was in a numb state.

The hardest, most embarrassing words had already been said. What came after wasn't difficult at all—like pouring beans out of a bamboo tube¹, all the words came spilling out.

"I wanted to divorce you because I thought you could have a better life, a better future without me. It's not that I don't love you. I chose to leave the place where I grew up to find you precisely because I love you."

"Xu Qingzhu, you're really wonderful. So, so wonderful that sometimes I feel like I don't deserve you. You're too perfect, just like Lu Jiayi. Your education, looks, personality, abilities, family background—everything is top-notch. So I often think, what can I do for you? It seems like I can't do anything."

"What I can do for you is utterly ordinary—any regular housekeeper or nanny could do it. But can I keep playing this role by your side forever? You'll get tired of me sooner or later, won't you? I always think, it would be better if I left before you got tired of me."

"As long as I leave first, you'll be sad for a while but then you'll get over it. A brighter future awaits you, and I won't have to constantly worry about gains and losses. I want to be with you, but I always overthink things. I don't want to become a burden in your life."

"I also don't want people to see us together and say, 'Oh, this person has nothing—is President Xu blind to fall for someone like this?' Whether it hurts my self-esteem is secondary. What matters most is that your reputation would be damaged."

"From beginning to end, I never said I don't love you. Maybe I don't love you as much as you love me, or as much as I love myself. But in this world, you really are the person I love the most."

"So please don't feel insecure, okay? Think about it—here, I'm close to almost no one but you. Only you know everything about me, know that I came from somewhere else, know that I have nowhere else to go. Where could I possibly go?"

When Liang Shi called Xu Qingzhu's name, it was slow and gentle.

She spoke these words unhurriedly, breaking the green pepper in her hands into small pieces, her eyes lowered.

"Xu Qingzhu, you really are wonderful. Please don't put yourself down just to keep me by your side, okay? I love you. No matter what, I love you. Even when you don't love me..."

She paused: "I'll still remember all those moments when you loved me, and love you."

Xu Qingzhu hadn't said anything the entire time. Her face was pressed against Liang Shi's shoulder, warm.

Liang Shi's voice was gentle yet sincere as she made a promise: "From now on, I'll try to do this."

It was just love, after all.

At worst, she'd be hurt until she was battered and bruised.

At least she would have loved.

Her previous timid behavior had caused psychological trauma to Xu Qingzhu. At worst, she could let Xu Qingzhu hurt her once—consider it repayment.

Love couldn't be measured on a scale, but one could decide whether to love and how deeply.

So she would love as deeply as she could.

To love once was to not waste a passionate life.

Liang Shi comforted herself this way.

After she finished speaking, the kitchen was silent for a long time.

Liang Shi nervously, cautiously asked: "Was I too blunt? I'm not saying you can't act or pretend. I just... don't want you to be so busy and still have to do these things with me. It's too hard on you. I'll love you anyway."

This clumsy supplementary excuse finally made Xu Qingzhu burst out laughing.

"What are you laughing at?" Liang Shi asked in a muffled voice.

Xu Qingzhu's head bumped against her back in small motions, one after another. First she laughed quietly, then buried herself in Liang Shi's back and laughed out loud, her whole body trembling.

Which made Liang Shi's body shake along with her.

Liang Shi didn't know what had happened.

She didn't think she'd said anything funny. She was being very serious.

But Xu Qingzhu's current reaction was unpredictable, so she could only wait and see.

After several long minutes, Xu Qingzhu finally spoke slowly: "Dummy."

With a hint of coquettish reproach.

Xu Qingzhu pressed her cheek against Liang Shi's thin back again and said quietly: "I don't think it's hard."

"Those days after you left the divorce agreement and walked away—that was hard." Xu Qingzhu said, "I felt like loving you was so hard. I didn't dare ask anything. Whatever you didn't want to say, I didn't ask. I don't know where you came from, where you're going. I don't even know who you are."

"But after thinking all that, I still couldn't help missing you. Wondering how you were doing out there, whether you'd eaten, whether you missed me, whether you were sad about the divorce—even if just for a moment."

"I thought about so many things... I even told myself to stop liking Liang Shi. But I couldn't control it. I just kept missing you. I just didn't want to divorce you. I just wanted to... keep you."

"What I did earlier was an act." Xu Qingzhu admitted, "I know..."

She paused, took a deep breath, as if summoning courage before saying: "Your personality weakness... so I used this method. But what can I do... you still saw through it..."

She spoke haltingly, her voice very low, using barely audible breaths when she felt guilty.

It was lucky the house was quiet. Liang Shi held her breath while listening to her.

So she could clearly hear every word she said.

"Would you call this prescribing the right medicine for the illness?" Liang Shi heard the nervousness in her voice and teased her warmly with a smile.

Hearing this, Xu Qingzhu shook her head, rubbing it against Liang Shi's back.

"It was a bit underhanded." Xu Qingzhu said quietly, "I'm sorry."

"What's there to be sorry about?" Liang Shi said, "If you hadn't pushed me, I'd still be hiding in my shell, too scared to come out, and I wouldn't be able to hold you."

Xu Qingzhu said in a muffled voice: "Don't you... find me scary like this?"

The kitchen suddenly fell silent. Liang Shi tossed the last piece of crushed green pepper into the plate, turned around and wrapped her arms around Xu Qingzhu, propping her hands up and trying to keep them away from her back.

"You dared to love someone as timid as me." Liang Shi kissed her forehead. "So what does it matter if I love someone as scary as you?"

In that moment, Xu Qingzhu looked up at her.

Fireworks suddenly exploded in her heart.

¹ **Pouring beans out of a bamboo tube (竹筒倒豆子):** A Chinese idiom meaning to confess everything completely and unreservedly, like how beans would all pour out at once when you tip over a bamboo tube. It describes speaking frankly without holding anything back.